

THE BIG IDEA

I. Find the “Big Idea” of a biblical narrative through the art of synthesis What is Synthesis?

The combination of components or elements to form a complete sentence.

Synthetic Method

“Worm’s eye view”
of the text

Analytical Method

“Bird’s eye view”
of the text

What is Synthetic Method?

- Synthetic Bible study method approaches the book / section / paragraph as a whole and seeks to understand its meaning as one idea.
- Unlike analytical method, it does not concern itself with detail...but it does not completely ignore the detail either!
- Bible Study should be a cyclical process that involves moving between analyze and synthesize

*“In Bible study methods, we have many analysts, but few who can synthesize.”
- Howard Hendriks –*

How?

- Read in one sitting
- Read repeatedly
- Read to understand a theme (e.g., suffering)
- Read to understand the action of a theme (e.g., endure suffering)
- Read to understand the argument of the theme (e.g., the way Christian endure suffering is by...)
- Read to develop an outline that will express the argument (sentence outline)

II. Formulate a Sentence Outline.

What is a Sentence Outline?

- It indicates the various levels of subordination that exist among the major ideas and supporting ideas of a passage / book
- It shows the relationships that exists between the main ideas and supporting ideas
- It uses a consistent series of indentations and symbols (numbers & letters)
- It presents “a picture” of the logical development of a passage

- The sentence outline is organized in levels:

Level 1- Big Idea (a.k.a “Central Idea” or “Thesis Statement”)

Level 2 - Main Ideas

Level 3 - Supporting Ideas

Level 4 – Supporting Details

- Each succeeding level contains more specific information than the preceding level (e.g., Level 3 has more detail than Level 2)

Sentence Outline – Basic Format

Big Idea (Book of Hezekiah 2:1-20)

- I. First Main Idea (2:1-5)
 - A. First Supporting Idea (2:1-2)
 - B. Second Supporting Idea (2:3-5)
- II. Second Main Idea (2:6-15)
 - A. First Supporting Idea (2:6-10)
 - 1. First Supporting Detail (2:6-9)
 - 2. Second Supporting Detail (2:10)
 - B. Second Supporting Idea (2:11-15)
- C. Third Main Idea (2:16-20)

Simple Outline vs. Sentence Outline

Simple Outline:

- I. God’s Call (2:1-20)
 - A. The Focus (2:1-5)
 - B. The Cause (2:6-10)
 - C. The Purpose (2:11-20)

Sentence Outline:

- I. God calls sinners because of His grace so that they might be saved. (2:1-20)
 - A. The focus of God’s call are sinners. (2:1-5)

Simple Outline

- B. The cause of God’s call is His grace. (2:6-10)
 - C. The purpose of God’s is so that sinners might be saved. (2:11-20)
- typically, only shows the headings and sub-headings more fully, in complete (usually a noun + identifier) without much elaboration
 - Advantage: full sentence enables the writer to express complete thoughts rather than fragments and generalization

Sentence Outline

Sentence Outline – General Considerations

- each idea (Big Idea, Main Idea, Supporting Idea) is a _____, _____ sentence
- each idea in the outline captures the essential point as briefly as possible (max _____ words)
- each idea has two parts: **Subject** (_____) + **Complement** (_____?)
- each supporting idea contributes to the main idea
- each main idea contributes to the Big Idea
- the Big Idea summarizes the main ideas of the passage and is also expressed with a complete sentence in an outline format.
- When constructing sentence outline, you follow a “synthetic” approach – i.e., you start with the lowest level, then move your way up until you read the Big Idea
- That is, you start with the support idea. Then integrate your supporting ideas to come up with the central idea. Then, you integrate the main ideas to come up with the heading sentence.

Idea Statement

“A single sentence statement of the main point of the text”
- Richards & Bredfeldt, *Creative Bible Teaching*

- An Idea Statement has two parts:
 1. Subject = What is the author talking about?
 2. Complement – What is the author saying about the subject?

Subject

- The subject is usually a short phrase, never one word.
 - ✗ Forgiveness
 - ✓ The reason for forgiveness is ...
- A subject cannot stand alone, since by itself it is incomplete. It must be accompanied by a complement:

*“**The reason for our forgiveness is...**”* (Subject)

must be accompanied by a complement

*“**...the grace of a merciful God.**”* (Complement)

to form the idea statement

*“**The reason for our forgiveness is the grace of a merciful God.**”* (Idea Statement)

- Behind every subject there is a question either stated or implied:

Example 1

Subject: “The reason for our forgiveness is ...”

Implied Question: “What is the reason for our forgiveness?”

Example 2

Subject: “The importance of faith is ...”

Implied Question: What is the importance of faith?

Complement

- The complement then answers the question: “What the author is saying about the subject?” That is, it provides a response to the implied question found in the subject (or the “content” necessary to complete the subject)

For example:

Subject: “The reason for our forgiveness is ...”

Implied Question: “What is the reason for our forgiveness?”

Complement: “...the grace of a merciful God.”

Idea statement: The reason for our forgiveness is the grace of a merciful God.

III. Write a “Big Idea” Statement

- It is the main argument or the message of the passage.
- It is the summation of all the main ideas found in the passage.
- Like all idea statement, it should follow the Subject + Complement format

IV. Who/What determines the meaning of a text?

Reader as Determiner of Meaning

- Reader-response approach—that each individual reader responds to the text by creating his/her meaning
- Meaning is often driven by reader’s concerns or agendas
- Contradictory or conflicting meaning is OK
- Rejects absolute, since “absolute” is incompatible with pluralistic society
- Most important question: “What does the text mean to me?”

Text as Determiner of Meaning

- After the author finishes writing, the text is viewed as “taking on a life of its own”—containing meanings beyond the original intent, even contrary to the desire of, the original author
- Hence, knowing the historical setting, cultural background of the author and original audience has little to no value
- Most important question: “What does the text say?” (NOTE: When people say, “what does the Bible say?” the speaker usually means “what does the inspired author say?”)

Author as Determiner of Meaning

- Author of the text ultimately decides the intended meaning of his writing—a common sense approach to communication
- Therefore, it is extremely important to study the historical setting, the culture context of the author and his original audience
- The role of the reader is to earnestly discover the author’s consciously-intended meaning, even if at times it may be difficult to determine the author’s meaning.
- Most important question: “What is the message the original author intends to communicate?”

V. Purpose of Biblical Narratives (Review)

Biblical narratives were written not merely to entertain, or to record a piece of human history; rather, they were written to convey precious theological truth from the author (Author).

VI. Review of *synthesis, synthetic method, sentence outline, idea statement, and Big Idea:* (see class notes from previous lesson)

- What is Synthesis?
- Synthetic Method – How?
- Sentence Outline
- Idea Statement = **Subject** (what is the author talking about?) + **Complement** (what is the author saying about the subject?)

- Big Idea = summation of all idea statements in the passage/book

VII. Practice – Luke 15

Based on the book chart, formulate the following:

- II. Simple Outline
- III. Sentence Outline
- IV. Big Idea for Luke 15

VIII. Challenge of formulating a Big Idea

